

— PARENT INTELLIGENCE REPORT

What to say instead: 7 phrases that build a growth mindset

Praising your child for being smart can backfire. Learn how to praise your child's effort the right way to build confidence, grit, and a growth mindset.

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THE CHALLENGE PARENTS FACE

You want your kid to feel good. So when they nail a spelling test or finally crack a tricky puzzle, it just slips out — "You're so smart!" Feels kind, right? Feels like the loving thing to say. Here's the catch: how you praise your child matters way more than anyone ever told us.

— THE 30-SECOND ANSWER

What to say instead: 7 phrases that build a growth mindset

QUICK ANSWER

Why does praising intelligence backfire? When you praise a child for being smart, they learn that success comes from a fixed trait they either have or don't. So they avoid hard tasks that might prove them "not smart." Praising effort teaches the opposite: that ability grows with practice, so challenges feel safe to try.

— WHAT THE RESEARCH SHOWS

A peer-reviewed study in *Frontiers in Psychology* found that kids praised for ability were more likely to give up and even hide their mistakes after a failure.

Sources: U.S. Dept. of Education | Child Mind Institute | *Frontiers in Psychology* | APA

DO THIS

What to say instead: 7 phrases that build a growth mindset

Work through these in order. Small, consistent reps beat one big push.

1**"You worked really hard on that."****2****"I saw you try three different ways****That's smart thinking."****3****"That was tricky, and you stuck with it."****4****"What part did you figure out yourself?"****5****"You're getting better at this every week."****6****"Mistakes are how your brain grows****What did this one teach you?"****7****"You didn't give up, even when it got boring."**

— KEEP AN EYE OUT

Effort praise vs intelligence praise: what's the difference?

- ✓ Intelligence praise: "You're so smart." → Message: success comes from talent you're born with.
- ✓ Effort praise: "You kept trying different ways until it worked." → Message: success comes from work you control.
- ✓ Intelligence praise makes mistakes feel scary. Effort praise makes mistakes feel useful.
- ✓ Intelligence praise wants to look smart. Effort praise wants to get better.

— COMMON QUESTIONS

Quick answers for parents

Should I never tell my child they're smart?

You don't have to ban the word. The goal is balance. If "smart" is the only praise your child hears, it can create pressure. Pair it with effort praise so they learn that working hard is what makes the brain grow.

What should I say instead of "good job"?

Be specific about what they did. Try "you planned that before you started" or "you kept going when it got hard." Specific, effort-focused praise teaches your child exactly which behavior to repeat.

Does effort praise work for teenagers too?

Yes. Teens are very tuned in to whether praise feels real, so keep it specific and honest. Notice the strategy, the practice, or the courage it took — not just the result.

My child gives up the moment something is hard. What helps?

Praise the attempt, not the outcome. Sit beside them, name one small thing they did well, and break the task into a single next step. Over time, effort praise rebuilds their willingness to struggle.

Can too much praise be harmful?

It can. Constant praise for everything makes praise meaningless and can make kids anxious about keeping it up. Praise that is specific, honest, and tied to effort is far more powerful than praise that is constant.

At what age should I start?

As early as toddlerhood. The words you use from ages 3 to 7 shape how your child sees ability. But it's never too late — effort praise helps at every age.

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